Google Pixel 11 Pro Fold

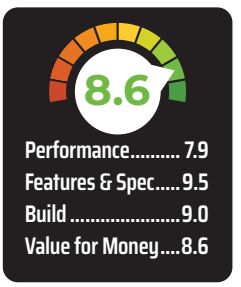
Google gets closer to the ideal foldable

The smartphone industry has come a long way in just over a decade. Almost 12 years ago, I was using the Galaxy S4 Mini and was quite impressed by the things a phone could do back then. Fast forward to 2026, and smartphones have evolved into devices that would have seemed almost impossible at the time, specifically foldables. These devices are now commercially available, and what was once an experimental form factor has become far more refined in terms of design, optimisation, innovation, repairability and durability.

That evolution, however, has also left the foldable market with a relatively small group of players. Google, Samsung, Motorola and Vivo are among the brands that have stuck around and pushed the category forward with regular updates. Google is now on its fourth generation of foldable smartphones globally, and it has chosen to stick with the conventional book-style foldable design rather than jumping to the passport-style form factor adopted by some of its rivals.

The Pixel 11 Pro Fold was introduced last month and rivals Samsung's Galaxy Z Fold 8 Ultra. On paper, the device brings a lighter design, a new Tensor chip and refinements to its display and camera setup. But beyond the key specifications, the bigger question is whether these changes are enough to make Google's foldable a compelling alternative. Of course, there is also the price factor. Like several other flagship and foldable smartphones in 2026, the Pixel 11 Pro Fold comes with a price hike and now costs Rs 1,86,999.





DESIGN

Google hasn't completely redesigned the Pixel 11 Pro Fold, but it has worked on the areas that mattered most. The biggest change is the weight. At 239 grams, it is nearly 10 per cent lighter than the Pixel 10 Pro Fold, which weighed 258 grams. That difference is immediately noticeable when you carry or use the phone for longer periods. Don't get me wrong, it is a sizable foldable, but it no longer feels as heavy as its predecessor.

Compared to the last-gen model, the Pixel 11 Pro Fold is also slimmer, measuring 10.1mm when folded and 5mm when unfolded. However, Samsung has taken things much further with the Galaxy Z Fold 8 Ultra, which measures just 8.9mm when folded and weighs only 215 grams. While the Pixel has become slimmer, it is not the phone to pick if your priority is having the thinnest and lightest foldable possible.

What I like about Google's approach is the shape. The Pixel 11 Pro Fold has a wider 20:9 outer display, making it feel much closer to a regular smartphone. You don't get the narrow, slightly awkward cover-screen experience associated with older foldables.

Google has also switched to a satin-textured glass-fibre composite rear panel, paired with an aluminium frame. It feels premium while being designed to withstand everyday knocks better than conventional glass. The camera module is smaller than before as well, which makes the rear look cleaner and reduces the amount of wobble when the phone is placed flat on a table.

The hinge has received an upgrade too. The new gearless mechanism allows the phone to close completely flat with a firm snap, while the wider bend radius helps reduce the visibility of the inner display crease. The crease is still there and becomes noticeable under direct light, but the overall hinge feels more refined than what we got on the previous generation.

Durability remains a strong point. The Pixel 11 Pro Fold gets ceramic cover glass on the outer display and retains an IP68 rating for dust and water resistance. That's particularly reassuring on a foldable, where durability is arguably more important because of the moving hinge and flexible inner display.

There are also a couple of interesting additions, including built-in magnetic support for Qi2 accessories and Google's new HiLight LEDs integrated into the rear camera module. The latter can glow to indicate notifications or Gemini.

DISPLAY

Google has done a lot right with the Pixel 11 Pro Fold's displays. You get an 8-inch LTPO OLED panel on the inside and a 6.5-inch OLED cover display, with both supporting a 120Hz refresh rate.

The outer display is one of the things I particularly like about the Pixel. Its 19.5:9 aspect ratio makes it feel much